

UNDERSTANDING SPIRITUALITY # 71

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Broaden understanding of spirituality and how it applies to overcoming addictions.
2. Learn the difference between religion and spirituality.
3. Overcome resistance to 12-step programs based on antipathy toward religion.
4. Develop a concept of a higher power that is loving and supportive to recovery.
5. Resolve spiritual conflicts, allowing for a meaningful relationship with a higher power.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE SPIRITUAL CONFUSION

- Interest and Skill Self-Assessment
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- What Do I Believe In?

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Understanding Spirituality” activity is written for clients whose therapeutic progress is impeded by antipathy toward spirituality as a resource for recovery based on antipathy toward organized religion or perceived conflicts with personal values. Follow-up could include bibliotherapy, including books such as *Where In the World is God* by Brizee.

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This assignment will help you begin working through an issue that troubles many people new to recovery programs. This is a big subject, and there is no way that one handout like this can cover it all, but it can offer some pointers to get started. Why work on spirituality? Because it can make the difference between success or failure in staying clean and sober, and therefore possibly the difference between life or death. It is the key to effective use of Alcoholics Anonymous (AA), Narcotics Anonymous (NA), and other 12-step programs.

When people attend their first meetings of 12-step programs and find they dislike these programs, the most common reason is discomfort with all the talk about God. This may look like a barrier making these programs useless to them, but it doesn't have to be.

Many people have good reasons to feel skeptical about religion. They may have had bad experiences with religious people or institutions. Perhaps they just feel that God has not been there in their lives. Hearing God or a Higher Power mentioned in 7 of the 12 Steps may be an immediate turn-off.

However, many people who either did not believe in God or believed that no one could know whether God exists have found that they can use AA, NA, and other 12-step programs to make the changes they want to make in their lives. *The key is understanding the difference between **spirituality** and **religion**.*

1. Write down your description of **religion**. What do you think of when you hear the word?

2. Now think about the word **spirituality**, and write your definition for this word.

3. Are there differences in the meanings of **religion** and **spirituality** for you? _____

If so, what is the biggest difference you see?

A definition of **religion** could be as follows:

A **religion** is a specific system of practices and rituals, based on a belief in a specific divine or superhuman power, usually practiced through membership in a specific human organization, usually called a church, temple, or mosque.

A similar definition for **spirituality**, on the other hand, might sound like this:

Spirituality is a focus on the moral aspects of life, on doing what is right, and what will help us to become the best people we are capable of being.

We could say it this way: A religion is a system created by people to try to achieve spirituality. We could think of spirituality as like water and religion as like a bottle, a container to hold water—but other containers can hold water, and some bottles contain other things instead of water.

4. Does this idea make sense to you? What other containers for spirituality can you think of (i.e., other ways to help yourself focus on what is right in life)?

5. At this point, you may be thinking, “Doesn’t this definition of *religion* also describe a 12-step program? It seems to be a specific system of practices and rituals, and it is practiced through membership in a specific organization!” Have you had the thought that AA, NA, or some other 12-step program seemed to resemble a church? _____ If so, what similarities do you see?

6. What differences do you see between 12-step groups and churches?

7. Here are three key differences between 12-step groups and churches:

- *Specific Definitions of God.* A church or religion offers specific ways to understand God, and may insist no other way is correct. A 12-step program asks you to think in terms of a power greater than yourself, and leaves it to you to decide what that power is and how it works.
- *Authority.* While a church normally has a formal hierarchy and structure of people in charge, in a 12-step group nobody is in charge. There is no chain of command. Decisions are made by the group through a vote called a “group conscience.”
- *Membership Requirements.* Religions may restrict their memberships in many ways—by birth, heritage, or obedience to various rules. By contrast, in any 12-step program, the 3rd Tradition says that the only membership requirement is a desire to solve the problem which that group exists to overcome. Anyone who wants to be a member can do so, and no one can be excluded.

How might these differences make a 12-step program work differently from a church?

8. Going back to our definition of spirituality, how do you think that paying attention to the moral aspects of life and what is right could help you solve the problems facing you with alcohol, other drugs, or other addictive behaviors?

If you see that a focus on these parts of your life could be useful, that's all it takes to begin including spirituality in your recovery work.